reserves space at the back of the book for the written traumas, including two about visits to the former death camps that were later reopened as commemorative sites of memory. As the final “trauma” of this section, Freed shares a story about picking up a German student hitchhiker en route to the town of Lübeck. Freed explains that this young man “had tried” a career in the army but now wished to be a school director. Here he goes on to recall their conversation: “Then he spoke of the Wall in Berlin. [He said] the problem was the Americans; they weren’t hard enough, not ready to fight.” After noting that the West Germans were weak, too, and lacking national pride, Freed relays, “He began speaking boldly … ‘one can’t talk too much because here in Germany, it’s such a hot topic, but other countries also wanted to get rid of their Jews. … Only Germany had the courage to do so.’”[52] In concluding this “trauma,” Freed states, “He left and I thought … keep faith, one must not abandon those Germans still fighting to uphold democratic ideals. … German democracy is still too fragile to survive without outside support.”[53]

This exchange is significant, in light of Freed’s overlapping photographic projects. Across each, democracy is an ideal rendered as fragile and paradoxical, operating both as a promise and a pitfall of Cold War American culture. He shares this anecdote to suggest that the Wall is a structure symbolic of democracy’s fragility in a post-Holocaust world, just as he explores it elsewhere as a place of American contradiction. Freed’s images produced in Germany and its divided landscape and people are poignant reminders of the urgency of the fight for such ideals in Europe. Freed’s image of a black soldier guarding a weeks-old Berlin Wall attests to a failure of American democracy to live up to its own ideals back home.